

THE POWER CENTRE PM Narendra Modi with CM Eknath Shinde and deputy CM Devendra Fadnavis in Kolhapur, Apr. 27

ANY INTERNAL RUMBLINGS, A VETERAN RSS CADRE BELIEVES, WILL BE FORGOTTEN IN THE MAJORITARIAN SENTIMENT THAT HAS CEMENTED THE BJP'S CORE BASE

Pawar Sr among their core, auxiliary and floating voters, but says the BJP has retained its core support among the middle and upper middle classes, and also expects to net the *labharthi* (beneficiary) vote. "Voter behaviour differs from election to election. We expect that some Marathi voters will vote for Modi in the Lok Sabha and return to Thackeray in the assembly polls," he claims. A Shinde Sena leader expresses the same confidence, saying "Modi versus the MVA candidate" could work in the Mahayuti's favour.

BJP leaders dismiss the sympathy claim outright. Fadnavis tells INDIA TODAY that it was Pawar who has "mastery when it comes to splitting parties". "Pawar split the Congress, the Sena, and other parties several times. At least, he should not be complaining," he says. "The two parties must introspect... on why their people walked out. There have been many instances where people went from the Opposition to the ruling party, but this is the first time ruling party members crossed over to the Opposition. People in those parties felt suffocated and felt their future was at risk." Yet, the party's moves to retain most of its MPs despite signs of local anti-incumbency, and getting smaller players like the Raj Thackeray-led Maharashtra Navnirman Sena on board, have reinforced a sense of defensiveness.

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Trouble is, things are not hunky-dory within the MVA either. Congress leaders are upset at Uddhav's Sena (UBT) and Pawar Sr's NCP (SCP) walking away with its traditional seats like Sangli and Bhiwandi. Grassroots coordination between the workers of the MVA parties leaves a lot to be desired, say sources. The inability to take along players like the Vanchit Bahujan Aghadi, led by Dr Babasaheb Ambedkar's grandson Prakash Ambedkar, and farmer leader Raju Shetti's Swabhimani Paksha may affect the combine in some seats despite a largely bipolar contest. Vote transfers, the cornerstone of any pre-poll alliance, are also a big 'if' for the two combines given the disparate nature of their constituents and the history of animosity.

What is also bolstering the BJP's confidence is that while there may not be a game-altering Modi wave like in 2014-2019, the Opposition has yet to throw up a figure of matching stature. The former BJP minister says as much: "There is no wave per se in our favour, but we expect TINA (There Is No Alternative) to work as a factor." After a long time, Fadnavis claims, "there is a government for which there is a visible pro-incumbency. People want to vote for Modi. He has personally touched lives across all sections. I don't think any other PM has done this." Says another BJP leader: "Till a pan-India party emerges as a challenger to the BJP, we have no fear. The only such pan-India party is the Congress, and it is in the doldrums."

Sanjay Raut, the outspoken Rajya Sabha MP from the Sena (UBT), flat out dismisses the TINA argument. "If there was no alternative, why did they split parties, engineer defections and misuse the agencies? They fear their imminent defeat...they are calculating for every seat and got Ashok Chavan to join them and gave him a Rajya Sabha berth just to win Nanded," he says. A source in the NCP has a different worry. He says while anti-incumbency seems palpable, especially in rural areas, the "enthusiasm" among voters is missing. "The people have developed an antipathy towards politics and politicians," he says. Local factors have taken precedence in many seats, he feels, but construes that as an advantage.

A senior Sena (UBT) leader points to how the BJP has ridden piggyback on defecting local satraps from the Congress and NCP to grow in some regions. This has upset loyalists for being ignored. But any internal rumblings, a veteran Rashtriya Swayamsevak Sangh cadre believes, will be forgotten in the majoritarian sentiment that has cemented its core base, and the Modi government's action on issues like Ayodhya and Article 370. "The Sangh completes its centenary in 2025, hence our cadre will work to ensure that a BJP government is in place when this happens," he adds. Raut counters with trenchant words: "The Ram temple is not the main issue. Inflation, unem-